

Experts recently classified severe premenstrual symptoms with marked mood changes that interfere with daily functioning as an official psychiatric diagnosis. This example reflects which perspective on health and illness?

- ☐ A. Conflict theory [6%]
- ☐ B. Functionalism [35%]
- ☐ C. Social exchange [5%]
- ✓ ☒ D. Social constructionism [53%]

Correct

53% answered correctly

Explanation:

Major theoretical approaches to sociology			
Theory	Description	Perspective	Theorists
Functionalism	- Society = an organism - Each part of society works to maintain dynamic equilibrium (homeostasis)	Macro	Émile Durkheim, Talcott Parsons
Conflict	- Society = struggle for limited resources - Inequality based on social class	Macro	Karl Marx, Max Weber
Social constructionism	- Social actors define what is real - Knowledge about world based on interactions	Macro or micro	(Not critical for exam)
Symbolic interactionism	- Meaning & value attached to symbols - Individual interactions based on these symbols	Micro	Charles Cooley, George Herbert Mead
Rational choice/social exchange	Individual behaviors & interactions attempt to maximize personal gain & minimize personal cost	Micro	(Not critical for exam)
Feminist	Examines gender inequality in society	Macro or micro	(Not critical for exam)

Social constructionism is a sociological theory suggesting that "reality" is created through interactions, resulting in **agreed-on, shared meanings**. Objects (eg, money), behaviors (eg, hand shaking), and categories (eg, gender) have meaning only because individuals in society have agreed on that meaning. For example, money has value in society only because everyone has *agreed that it has value*; this makes money a **social construct**.

Redefining severe premenstrual symptoms as an official psychiatric diagnosis reflects experts' consensus that a particular set of symptoms should be treated as a psychiatric disorder, thereby demonstrating an agreed-on, shared meaning (ie, the social constructionism perspective).

(Choice A) Conflict theory, a macrosociological perspective that examines how inequalities between social classes cause conflict, does not deal with the creation of agreed-on, shared meaning.

(Choice B) Functionalism, a macrosociological perspective that analyzes how social structures work together in society to maintain equilibrium, does not deal with the creation of agreed-on, shared meaning.

(Choice C) Social exchange theory, a microsociological perspective that asserts that individuals interact with each other to maximize personal gain and minimize personal cost, does not deal with the creation of agreed-on, shared meaning.

Educational objective:

Social constructionism is a sociological theory suggesting that "reality" is created through interactions, resulting in agreed-on, shared meanings (social constructs). Social constructs (eg, gender) are defined and maintained through the process of social interaction.

Time spent:0 sec
Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

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System:
Demographics and Social Structure

Some studies have found an association between situational stress and intrafamily violence; when certain individuals experience a defeat, they react to this stress with violence toward a family member. Which of the following provides the best explanation for these findings?

- ☐ A. Conflict theory [4%]
- ☐ B. Optimal arousal theory [2%]
- ☐ C. Incentive theory
- ✓ ☒ D. Frustration-aggression theory [92%]

Correct

92% answered correctly

Explanation:

Social institutions (eg, family) are enduring, organized systems that outline behavioral norms and fulfill a purpose in society. Family is broadly defined as at least two individuals connected by an intimate relationship (eg, marriage/partnership, birth, adoption) who often live together.

Abuse within families can take many forms, including physical violence, emotional harm, neglect, and/or isolation. Family members subject to abuse may

include partners (spousal abuse), children (child abuse), or older relatives (elder abuse). Intrafamily violence is most often explained with social learning theory, which posits that individuals who commit violence are modeling behaviors they've seen in the past (eg, one's father hitting one's mother).

Another perspective on intrafamily violence, the **frustration-aggression theory**, contends that individuals exhibit **violence** as a **result** of having a goal or effort blocked or defeated (ie, frustration). Therefore, intrafamily violence resulting from an individual experiencing stress from a defeat is best explained by the frustration-aggression theory.

(Choice A) Conflict theory, a macro-level approach focusing on how inequalities between social classes cause conflict, would consider the broader social inequalities that contribute to intrafamily violence, not the micro-level factors (eg, frustration) that cause individual behaviors (eg, aggression).

(Choice B) Optimal arousal theory, which suggests that an optimal level of physiological or mental arousal maximizes performance (eg, test performance declines with too little or too much arousal), does *not* best explain the causes of intrafamily violence.

(Choice C) Incentive theory, which suggests that external rewards (eg, money) motivate individuals to engage in behavior resulting in the most desirable outcomes, does *not* best explain the causes of intrafamily violence.

Educational objective:

Abuse within families can take many forms, including physical violence, emotional harm, neglect, and/or isolation. The frustration-aggression theory proposes that individuals exhibit aggression as a result of frustration (ie, having a goal or effort blocked or defeated).

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Behavioral Sciences

Demographics and Social Structure